Edutechlife

MODULE 1 · FOUNDATIONS

What Generative AI Is

How it works, what it can and cannot do, and how to use it with judgment

Module 1
IALab · Edutechlife

Teaching guide 2026
Teaching guide

edutechlife.co
Content 2026

Generative AI produces text, images, audio and code from patterns learned from enormous amounts of data. It does not **know** the way a person does: it predicts what makes most sense after what you have written. Understanding that difference is the foundation of everything you will do in this course.

3	4	1
types of AI worth telling apart	limits to remember	golden rule: verify

01 What it is and how it learns

A generative model is trained on text and other data to predict the next piece of information: a word, a fragment of an image or a voice tone. By repeating that prediction billions of times, it learns the structures of language, reasoning and style.

That is why it can write a convincing email without having read yours: it does not retrieve a stored answer, it builds one.

CORE IDEA

Generative AI builds plausible answers. Plausible does not always mean correct, which is why verification is part of the work.

02 Three types of AI worth telling apart

Type	What it does	Everyday example
Narrow AI	Solves one specific task very well	Spam filter, face unlock on your phone
Generative AI	Creates new content from a request	Drafting an email, generating an image, summarizing a report
General AI (hypothetical)	Would match human versatility across any task	Does not exist yet; do not confuse it with today's tools

03 What it does well

Transform

Summarize, rewrite, translate or change the tone of your own text.

Structure

Turn messy notes into outlines, tables or step-by-step lists.

Explore

Generate ideas, alternatives and questions to think a problem through.

Accelerate

Produce a first draft in minutes that you then review and improve.

04 Its limits you must remember

1. **It can invent:** figures, quotes and references with complete confidence (so-called hallucinations).
2. **It does not have your context:** whatever you do not tell it, it guesses.
3. **It inherits biases:** its training data can repeat stereotypes.
4. **It changes over time:** models, plans and prices are updated often.

05 How to use it with judgment

Use AI to start, organize and review. You decide the final content, verify what matters and disclose when you used it.

- [ ] Before using a figure or quote, I checked it against the original source.
- [ ] I tell the model what I need, for whom, and with which limits.
- [ ] I did not share personal or confidential data.
- [ ] I disclose AI use when the result goes out under my name.

TO WRAP UP

- [ ] I can tell narrow, generative and hypothetical general AI apart.
- [ ] I know it can invent, and I verify what matters.
- [ ] I use AI to start and review, not to think for me.